

About: topics and movement

Teaching guide

Use about for a topic and recognize its other meanings.

Understand the distinction

About often means on the subject of: talk about a film, think about a question, read about a place. It does not automatically make an action longer or more detailed.

Verb patterns differ. Discuss normally takes its topic directly: discuss the plan. Talk usually needs about before a topic. About can also mean approximately or around a place: about ten minutes; walk about the room.

Compare the patterns

TOPIC

We talked about the trip.

The trip is the subject of the conversation.

DIRECT OBJECT

We discussed the trip.

No about is needed in this pattern.

AROUND

She walked about the room.

About describes movement around a place.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: We discussed about the price.

2. Does think about tell us how long someone thinks?

3. What does about mean in about twenty people?

Use it in your own life

Write one sentence with talk about and another with discuss.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. We discussed the price.

Discuss takes a direct object for its topic.

2. No. It introduces the topic.

Duration needs additional context, such as for ten minutes.

3. Approximately.

This is a quantity meaning, not a topic.

One possible response

We talked about the schedule. We discussed a possible change.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-07.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write one sentence with talk about and another with discuss.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.